Pakistan) coalition-building internationally.[126] This regional coercive strategy of which India became a part in late 1996 was key in keeping the partisans dominant over the conciliators in May 1997 when Mazar-e-Sharif fell to the Taliban temporarily.[127] India wanted to lobby Washington as well, but the US was on a different page. Not having experienced serious violence on its own territory or against its citizens, the US did not view localised Islamist insurgencies abroad as a national threat in 1996.

As detailed by Pakistani journalist Ahmed Rashid, American oil companies were busy eyeing Central Asian oil reserves and hosting Taliban delegations in the US to lobby for their support.[128] Washington's policy beliefs shifted somewhat in August 1998 after its embassies in Nairobi and Dar-es-Salaam were bombed. But they were altered decisively after the 9/11 attacks. If the international dynamic was critical in increasing the partisans' influence on India's Afghanistan policy behavior in 1996 and 1997, how did the situation on Afghanistan impact this between 1998 and 2001? Just like the Mujahideen in 1992, the Taliban wanted to engage with New Delhi. Though it was wary of India's support to the UF, the Taliban knew that the only country in the region that can really balance Pakistan's influence on Afghan affairs was India. On the morning of 25 December 1999, top Taliban leadership in Kandahar woke up to just such an opportunity. The Taliban, from their perspective would do everything right. However, eight days after Christmas, to the Taliban's perennial wonder, instead of being thankful, the Indians began hating the Taliban even more.

'A basket of worst alternatives'

At 4.53 PM, exactly twenty Christmas eves after the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, at the dawn of the twenty-first century, India's worst nightmare vis-à-vis Afghanistan came true.[129] Five armed men belonging to Pakistan-based *Harkat-ul-Ansar* (later called *Harkat-ul-Mujahideen*) hijacked the Indian Airlines flight IC-814 en-route to Delhi from Kathmandu.[130] The plane was first taken to Amritsar where Indian authorities were unable to hold it. After Amritsar it was forced to land in Lahore, where Pakistani authorities re-fuelled it and subsequently the plane was taken to Dubai. In Dubai, after negotiations, twenty-